It was only during the crisis that engulfed the government, with 22 Congress MLAs resigning and joining the BJP with Jyotiraditya Scindia in March 2020 that appointments were made. Among those appointed on March 16 that year included Shobha Oza as chairperson of the Women's Commission, Anand Ahirwar as chairman of the SC Commission, Gajendra Singh Rajukhedi as head of the ST Commission and J.P. Dhanopia as chief of the OBC Commission, besides members in the commissions. All were Congress leaders who resigned from the party's primary membership before their appointments, as mandated by law. A week later, one of the first orders of the new Chouhan government was to annul the appointments. The affected members

**COMMISSION CHIEFS, MEMBERS WERE NOT PAID AND PREVENTED FROM ATTENDING OFFICE**

and heads appealed at the high court through different writ petitions. In the case on Oza's appointment, the HC granted a 'status quo ante' on May 22, 2020. Other members and chairpersons were not paid any emoluments and were prevented from attending office. The cases continue at the high court.

Meanwhile, the state government has not made any fresh appointments, given the 'status quo ante' order involving Oza, who resigned in June 2022. In case the HC does not issue an order, the appointments will lapse in March 2023. Currently, in the absence of members and heads, member secretaries of the commissions are exercising their powers. ■

WEST BENGAL

# DIDI PLAYS THE DOLE DRUMS

**By Romita Datta**

In the jousting field that is West Bengal politics, the incumbent Trinamool Congress finds itself on the backfoot. Two of its heavyweight leaders—former minister Partha Chatterjee and Birbhum strongman Anubrata Mondal—have been arrested by the Enforcement Directorate and the Central Bureau of Investigation for their alleged involvement in the teachers' recruitment scandal and the cattle smuggling scam respectively. Add to that the repeated CBI summons to party national general secretary and second-in command Abhishek Banerjee in the ongoing probe in the alleged coal scam. In the not too distant past, too, loom the dark visages of the Saradha and Narada scams, which created no less embarrassment for the TMC. Add to that infighting in the party and a spate of crimes in recent months, including rape, allegedly linked to TMC members—all leading to a palpable lack of confidence in the TMC amongst the public. And, as central agencies cast their nets wider into ongoing probes, cries of *chor dhoro/ jail bhoro* (catch the crook/ put him in jail) by the opposition BJP and Left fill the air.

Something, then, needs to be done to save the situation for the Trinamool. Yet most of its top leaders are apprehensive of reaching out to people for fear of facing questions on the corruption allegations. Women leaders with a clean image like Chandrima Bhattacharya and Sashi Panja were mobilised to counter what TMC terms is vendetta politics by the BJP-led Centre. However, the crowds attending their meetings are noticeably thinner than before. In short, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has suffered a loss of face. Mute disbelief has greeted her defence that only a minority in her party is corrupt; neither are people willing to believe that she was totally in the dark while her trusted lieutenant Chatterjee was allegedly involved in selling teaching jobs for money. Clearly, no one feels the trust deficit more than Mamata. As a way out of the deepening morass, Mamata has arrived at a two-pronged strategy. One is heightening the pitch of celebrations and carnivals this festive season. The other, and more important, ploy is that time-tested political panacea—a generous grant of doles.

Mamata's much-touted walk-cum-rally on September 1 in Kolkata to celebrate UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage (ICH) tag for the city's Durga Puja celebrations was one such effort. The UNESCO

**TO GET OVER A TRUST DEFICIT WITH TMC, MAMATA HAS HIKED DOLE AMOUNTS**